

Maschke's Theorem and Its Proof

Theorem 1 (Maschke). *Let G be a finite group, and let*

$$\rho : G \longrightarrow \mathrm{GL}(V)$$

be a finite-dimensional representation of G over a field $\mathbb{F}$. If

$$\mathrm{char}(\mathbb{F}) \nmid |G|,$$

then ρ is completely reducible. More precisely, for every G -invariant subspace $W \subseteq V$, there exists a G -invariant subspace $U \subseteq V$ such that

$$V = W \oplus U.$$

Equivalently, every G -invariant subspace has a G -invariant complement.

Proof. The central idea of the proof is *averaging*. Since the group is finite, we can average an arbitrary linear projection over the group action and thereby turn it into a G -equivariant projection.

Step 1: Construct an arbitrary linear projection

Let $W \subseteq V$ be a G -invariant subspace. By linear algebra, we may choose a basis

$$\{w_1, \dots, w_m\}$$

of W , and extend it to a basis

$$\{w_1, \dots, w_m, u_1, \dots, u_k\}$$

of V . Define a linear map

$$\pi : V \longrightarrow W$$

by

$$\pi(w_i) = w_i, \quad \pi(u_j) = 0, \quad i = 1, \dots, m, \quad j = 1, \dots, k.$$

Then

$$\pi|_W = \mathrm{id}_W, \quad \mathrm{im}(\pi) = W, \quad \pi^2 = \pi.$$

Thus π is a projection onto W . However, π is not necessarily G -equivariant; it is merely a linear projection.

Step 2: Average the projection

Define a new linear map $\tilde{\pi} : V \rightarrow V$ by

$$\tilde{\pi}(v) = \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} \rho(g) \pi(\rho(g)^{-1}v), \quad v \in V.$$

The scalar $|G|^{-1}$ exists in $\mathbb{F}$, because $\text{char}(\mathbb{F}) \nmid |G|$.

Intuitively, for each $g \in G$, we first pull v back by $\rho(g)^{-1}$, project it onto W using π , push the result forward by $\rho(g)$, and then average over all group elements.

Step 3: Verify the key properties of $\tilde{\pi}$

(a) **The image of $\tilde{\pi}$ is contained in W .** For any $v \in V$ and $g \in G$, we have

$$\pi(\rho(g)^{-1}v) \in W.$$

Since W is G -invariant, applying $\rho(g)$ keeps the vector inside W . Hence

$$\rho(g) \pi(\rho(g)^{-1}v) \in W.$$

Therefore the finite sum also lies in W , and so

$$\text{im}(\tilde{\pi}) \subseteq W.$$

(b) **The map $\tilde{\pi}$ restricts to the identity on W .** Let $w \in W$. Since W is G -invariant, we have

$$\rho(g)^{-1}w \in W.$$

Because $\pi|_W = \text{id}_W$,

$$\pi(\rho(g)^{-1}w) = \rho(g)^{-1}w.$$

Therefore

$$\rho(g) \pi(\rho(g)^{-1}w) = \rho(g) \rho(g)^{-1}w = w.$$

Thus every term in the average equals w , so

$$\tilde{\pi}(w) = \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} w = w.$$

Consequently,

$$\tilde{\pi}|_W = \text{id}_W.$$

Together with $\text{im}(\tilde{\pi}) \subseteq W$, this implies

$$\text{im}(\tilde{\pi}) = W \quad \text{and} \quad \tilde{\pi}^2 = \tilde{\pi}.$$

(c) **The map $\tilde{\pi}$ is G -equivariant.** Let $h \in G$ and $v \in V$. Then

$$\begin{aligned}\tilde{\pi}(\rho(h)v) &= \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} \rho(g) \pi(\rho(g)^{-1} \rho(h)v) \\ &= \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{g \in G} \rho(g) \pi(\rho(g^{-1}h)v).\end{aligned}$$

Now set $t = h^{-1}g$, so $g = ht$. As g ranges over G , so does t . Hence

$$\begin{aligned}\tilde{\pi}(\rho(h)v) &= \frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{t \in G} \rho(ht) \pi(\rho(t)^{-1}v) \\ &= \rho(h) \left(\frac{1}{|G|} \sum_{t \in G} \rho(t) \pi(\rho(t)^{-1}v) \right) \\ &= \rho(h) \tilde{\pi}(v).\end{aligned}$$

Therefore $\tilde{\pi}$ is a G -equivariant projection onto W .

Step 4: Take the kernel to obtain a G -invariant complement

Define

$$U = \ker(\tilde{\pi}) = \{u \in V \mid \tilde{\pi}(u) = 0\}.$$

Since $\tilde{\pi}$ is a projection with image W , linear algebra gives

$$V = \text{im}(\tilde{\pi}) \oplus \ker(\tilde{\pi}) = W \oplus U.$$

It remains only to check that U is G -invariant. If $u \in U$, then $\tilde{\pi}(u) = 0$. For any $g \in G$, using G -equivariance gives

$$\tilde{\pi}(\rho(g)u) = \rho(g)\tilde{\pi}(u) = \rho(g)0 = 0.$$

Thus $\rho(g)u \in U$, so U is G -invariant.

We have therefore found a G -invariant complement U of W , namely

$$V = W \oplus U.$$

□

Corollary 1 (Complete reducibility). *Under the hypotheses of Maschke's theorem, every finite-dimensional representation of G is a direct sum of irreducible subrepresentations.*

Proof. If V is irreducible, there is nothing to prove. Otherwise, choose a nonzero proper G -invariant subspace $W \subsetneq V$. By Maschke's theorem, there is a G -invariant subspace U such that

$$V = W \oplus U.$$

Both W and U have strictly smaller dimension than V . Repeating the argument and using induction on $\dim V$, we obtain

$$V = V_1 \oplus V_2 \oplus \cdots \oplus V_r,$$

where each V_i is irreducible.

□

Key Idea. The proof rests on four points:

1. Linear algebra provides an arbitrary projection $\pi : V \rightarrow W$.
2. Averaging over the finite group turns π into a G -equivariant projection $\tilde{\pi}$.
3. The change of variables in the group sum proves equivariance.
4. The kernel of $\tilde{\pi}$ is automatically a G -invariant complement of W .